Mubarak Shah, offered a daughter to Akbar as a sign of allegiance. Finally, in October, followed by hundreds of captured elephants, a new bride, and a bolstered sense of confidence and purpose, the Mughal train reached Agra.

Late in 1564, twins were born to Akbar, Hussain and Hasan, but the boys died within a month of their birth. Almost immediately, Akbar began work on the first of his construction projects. First a hunting lodge was built outside Agra called Nagarchain (City of Rest), then orders were given to build a new stone fort at Agra, to replace the now decrepit brickwork of the earlier Badalgarh Fort*. According to art historian Jeremiah Losty, this early Akbari architectural style was 'a synthesis formed from the Indo-Islamic regional styles of Gujarat and Bengal, combined with earlier Hindu ideas on architectural symbolism…' Akbar was willing to borrow and innovate to develop an aesthetic which would be a true reflection of his rule. Under the supervision of Qasim Khan, Mir-Barr-u-Bahr (Lord of the Land and Sea), 1,000 cartloads of red sandstone were brought daily from Sikri Ridge to Agra. According to Shirazi, some 3,000 qalandars and other mendicants were rounded up and used as labour at Agra Fort under the supervision of 300 expert craftsmen at a daily wage of one Akbari tanka. These ex-mendicants could now afford simple meals of khichdi, with pickle, and possibly even ghee, as the cost of goat meat, ghee, and milk was relatively low in the sixteenth century. Slavery had already been abolished by Akbar a few years previously and Shirazi, travelling through Agra, now had the opportunity to see how the measure was being implemented.

> During those days I set out from Agra for Gujarat. I had a companion. He sold a slave (at Agra). On coming to know about this (transaction) the Kotwal of the city arrested the (original) owner of the slave and carried him to the gate of the fort where his ears were pierced with a pin so that it should serve as a warning to other men.

In Agra, hewn stones of a fiery red colour were used to raise colossal walls and imposing gates. The palace complex, according to historian Michael Fisher, was built using Akbar's early architectural aesthetic— uniform red sandstone surfaces highlighted with white marble. Apart from the palace itself, Monserrate wrote of the 'mansions of his nobles, the magazines, the treasury, the arsenal, the stables of the cavalry, the shops and huts of drug-sellers, barbers, and all manner of common workmen'. According to Abu'l